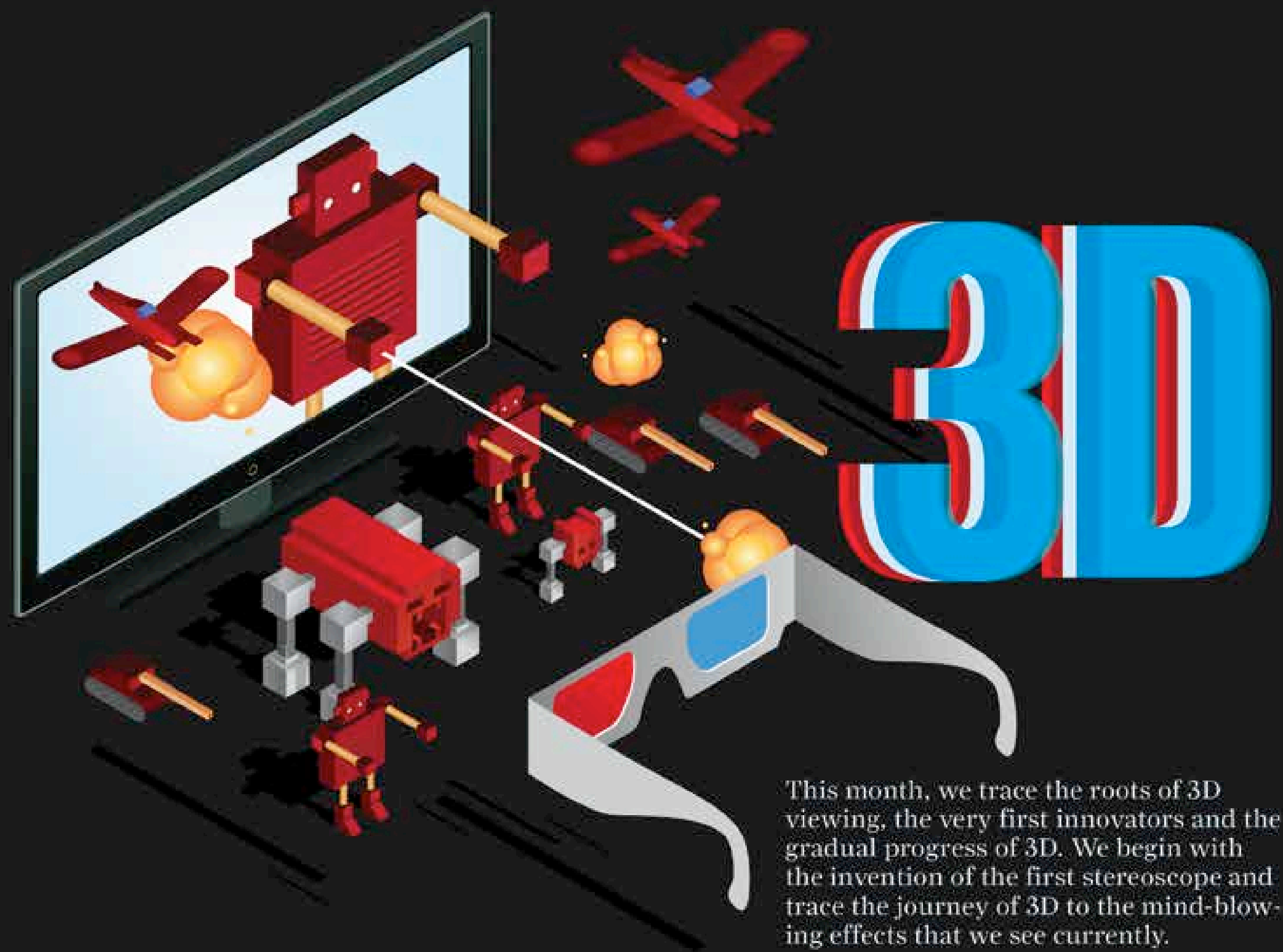

3D

This month, we trace the roots of 3D viewing, the very first innovators and the gradual progress of 3D. We begin with the invention of the first stereoscope and trace the journey of 3D to the mind-blowing effects that we see currently.

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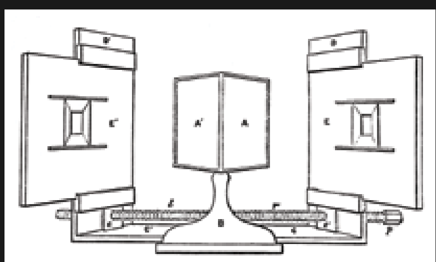
3D viewing is not as young a craft as we commonly perceive it to be. Back in 1838, Sir Charles Wheatstone invented one of the first and very basic forms of stereoscope, using two mirrors tilted at 45 degrees to the viewer's eyes. The instrument illustrated the impact that binocular depth perception of an image had. It also showed what roughly translates to 3D viewing of today. The mechanism presented images of the subject in question to the left and right eyes, separately, and successfully showed how the brain can perceive such images with a sense of depth. This very first instance of 3D vision, or a stereoscope, was a bare bones structure that did not even employ lenses, and came a year before the very first photograph was produced.

The first perception of depth

Sir Charles' stereoscope used a painting and showed a three-dimensional version to intrigued audiences. About a decade later, in 1849, Scottish physicist Sir David Brewster constructed the world's first lenticular telescope. He was the first to use lenses in the construction of a stereoscope, thereby making the devices much smaller in size. The stereoscopes became portable, and the initial handheld stereoscopes became known as Brewster Stereoscopes. After failing on his quest to find instrument makers in the United Kingdom who could work on his design of the stereoscope, Sir Brewster headed to France, where he met Louis Jules Duboscq, a French instrument maker famous for being one of the earliest patrons of photography. Duboscq would go on to tweak his stereoscope and market them, suddenly creating widespread demand for the 3D viewing stereoscopes and gave birth to the 3D industry.


Wheatstone's initial design of the stereoscope

The initial, miraculously realistic results that the stereoscopes gave caught the attention of Queen Victoria, and Sir Brewster's work was exhibited